SAMPLE

Revelation: The Word from the Unseen

Wahy in the Quran

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Introduction

The Quran is not a book that was written. It is a book that was given. The difference is everything. A book that is written is the product of human thought, human effort, and human limitation. A book that is given is the product of divine speech, divine will, and divine knowledge. The Quran presents itself as the latter -- the spoken word of Allah, transmitted through the unseen to a human prophet, and preserved in the world of the seen. The process by which this transmission occurred is called *wahy* -- revelation.

Revelation is the bridge between the unseen and the seen. It is the mechanism by which Allah, who is beyond perception, communicates with human beings, who are bound by perception. Without revelation, the human being would know nothing of Allah beyond what their senses could discover -- the existence of a creation implies a Creator, but the nature of that Creator, His will, His commands, and His promises would remain hidden. Revelation is the answer to this hiddenness. It is Allah speaking -- not in a voice that echoes through the sky, but through a process that traverses the unseen world and arrives in the human heart.

This book is the fourth in the Unseen sub-series of the NurOne project. The first three books explored the inhabitants of the unseen: the angels, the jinn, and Shaytan. This book explores the communication that comes from the unseen -- the revelation that Allah sends to His prophets through the angel Jibril. It is a book about the word of Allah: how it comes, why it comes, what it brings, and how it is preserved.

The Quranic treatment of revelation is extensive. The Quran describes the process, the medium, the timing, the purpose, and the preservation of revelation. It describes the Prophet's experience of receiving it -- the weight, the difficulty, and the transformation. It describes the previous revelations -- to Musa, to Isa, to Ibrahim, to Nuh -- and situates the Quran within the broader tradition of divine communication. And it describes the response to revelation -- belief and disbelief, acceptance and rejection, guidance and misguidance.

The Quran describes revelation as the highest form of knowledge -- knowledge that comes not from human observation or reasoning but from the One who created both the observer and the observed. It is knowledge that transcends the limits of human perception and reaches into the unseen. Through revelation, the human being learns what they could never discover on their own: the nature of Allah, the purpose of existence, the destiny of the soul, and the terms of the relationship between the created and the Creator. Without revelation, the human being would be adrift in a vast universe with no map, no compass, and no destination. With revelation, the map is given, the compass is set, and the destination is clear.

The word *wahy* in Arabic carries the meaning of a swift, secret communication -- a signal that is sent quickly and quietly. The root *w-h-y* appears in the Quran in several contexts: the revelation to the prophets, the inspiration of the bees (16:68), the command to the earth (99:5), and the communication between Allah and the angels. In every case, *wahy* denotes a communication that is direct, efficient, and beyond the ordinary channels of human discourse. It is the language of the unseen speaking to the seen.

Chapter 1: The Meaning of Wahy -- Allah Speaks

The Quran does not define *wahy* in a single verse. Instead, it shows *wahy* in action -- through its descriptions of how Allah communicates with His prophets, how the message arrives, and what it carries. From these descriptions, a clear picture emerges.

The Root Meaning

The Arabic word *wahy* (وَحْي) is derived from a root meaning "to signal," "to inspire," or "to communicate swiftly and secretly." The word carries the sense of a communication that bypasses ordinary channels -- it does not arrive through speech that is heard with the ears or writing that is read with the eyes. It arrives through a process that is both internal and divine. The Quran uses the word in several ways:

Allah reveals to the prophets: "Indeed, We have revealed to you as We revealed to Nuh and the prophets after him" (4:163). Allah inspires the bees: "And your Lord inspired the bee: take for yourself among the mountains, houses, and among the trees and that which they construct" (16:68). Allah commands the earth: "And the earth will shine with the light of its Lord, and the Book will be laid, and the prophets and the witnesses will be brought, and it will be judged between them in truth, and they will not be wronged" (39:69 -- though this uses different terminology). Allah communicates with the angels: "When your Lord said to the angels: I am with you, so strengthen those who have believed" (8:12 -- though this is described as speech, not *wahy*). And Allah speaks to Musa directly: "And to Musa, Allah spoke directly" (4:164 -- *kalim*, not *wahy*).

The variety of usage shows that *wahy* is not a single, uniform process. It is a category of divine communication that takes different forms depending on the recipient and the purpose. The revelation to the prophets is the most significant form -- it is the communication of divine guidance, law, and warning to human messengers.

The Modes of Revelation

The Quran identifies three modes of divine communication to the prophets. The first is through an intermediary -- the angel Jibril. The Quran says: "He sends down the angels with the Spirit of His command upon whom He wills of His servants, saying: warn that there is no deity except Me, so fear Me" (16:2). This is the most common mode -- Jibril carries the message from Allah to the prophet.

The second is direct speech -- without an intermediary. The Quran says: "And it is not for any human being that Allah should speak to him except by revelation (*wahy*) or from behind a partition or that He sends a messenger to reveal, by His permission, what He wills. Indeed, He is Most High and Wise" (42:51). This verse is the Quran's most explicit description of the modes of divine communication. The first mode is *wahy* -- direct inspiration placed in the heart. The second is "from behind a partition" -- a voice without a visible speaker, as in the case of Musa. The third is "a messenger" -- the angel Jibril, who is sent to deliver the message.

The third mode -- the sending of a messenger -- is the most elevated, because it involves the angelic intermediary. The Quran says: "And We did not send any messenger except that he should be obeyed by permission of Allah" (4:64). The messenger -- both the human prophet and the angel Jibril -- is the vehicle through which the divine word reaches the human world.

The Content of Revelation

The Quran describes what revelation contains: guidance, law, warning, good news, stories, parables, and descriptions of the unseen. The Quran says: "Alif, Lam, Ra. This is a Book which We have revealed to you that you might bring mankind out of darkness into the light by permission of their Lord -- to the path of the Exalted in Might, the Praiseworthy" (14:1). Revelation brings people "out of darkness into the light" -- from ignorance to knowledge, from disbelief to faith, from aimlessness to purpose.

The Quran also says: "And We have sent down to you the Book as clarification for all things and as guidance and mercy and good tidings for the Muslims" (16:89). The word "clarification" (*tibyan*) indicates that revelation is not obscure -- it is clear, comprehensive, and explanatory. It addresses all things that the believer needs -- not in exhaustive detail, but in principle and guidance. The revelation is "guidance" (*huda*) -- it points the way. It is "mercy" (*rahma*) -- it is given out of compassion, not compulsion. And it is "good tidings" (*bushra*) -- it brings the news of forgiveness and Paradise for those who follow it.

The Necessity of Revelation

The Quran implies that revelation is necessary because human reason, while capable of recognizing the existence of a Creator, is insufficient to determine the nature of that Creator or the terms of the relationship between the Creator and the created. The Quran says: "And they will not remember unless Allah wills. He is worthy of fear and suitable for forgiveness" (74:56 -- in the context of revelation). Human reason can deduce that the universe has a cause, but it cannot determine whether that cause is one or many, whether it has a will, whether it communicates, and what it requires of its creatures. These questions are answered only by revelation.

The Quran also presents revelation as the continuation of a pattern that began with the first human being. Adam received communication from Allah: "Then Adam received from his Lord words, and his Lord turned to him in forgiveness" (2:37). Every prophet after Adam received revelation. The Quran says: "Indeed, We have revealed to you as We revealed to Nuh and the prophets after him. And We revealed to Ibrahim and Isma'il and Ishaq and Yaqub and the descendants and Isa and Ayyub and Yunus and Harun and Sulayman. And to Dawud We gave the Psalms. And We have revealed to you, and to Musa, and to Isa, and to Nuh" (4:163-164 -- paraphrased). Revelation is not a novel event -- it is the ongoing communication between the Creator and His creation, spanning all of human history.
